Snow Glass Apples

By Neil Gaiman

INTRODUCTION

Once upon a time there lived a young princess with skin as white as snow, with hair as black as coal, with lips redder than blood. Most people think they know what happens to this young unfortunate girl. Most people are wrong. Snow Glass Apples by Neil Gaiman

I do not know what manner of thing she is. None of us do. She killed her mother in the birthing, but that's never enough to account for it.

They call me wise, but I am far from wise, for all that I foresaw fragments of it, frozen moments caught in pools of water or in the cold glass of my mirror. If I were wise I would not have tried to change what I saw. If I were wise I would have killed myself before ever I encountered her.

Wise, and a witch, or so they said. I'd seen his face in my dreams and in reflections for all my life:

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sixteen years of dreaming of him before he reined his horse by the bridge that morning, and asked my name. His beard was red-bronze in the morning light, and I knew him, not as a king, for I knew nothing of kings then, but as my love. His daughter was only a child: no more than five years of age when I came to the palace. One night, several months after I was brought to the palace, she came to my rooms. She was six.

"Princess?"

She said nothing. Her eyes were black as coal, black as her hair; her lips were redder than blood. She looked up at me and smiled. Her teeth seemed sharp, even then, in the lamplight.

"I'm hungry," she said, like any child.

It was winter, when fresh food is a dream of warmth and sunlight; but I had strings of whole apples, cored and dried, hanging from the beams of my chamber, and I pulled an apple down for her.

She took the dried apple from me and began to chew it with her sharp yellow teeth.

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I had always been scared of the little princess, but at that moment I warmed to her and, with my fingers, gently, I stroked her cheek. She looked at me and smiled -- she smiled but rarely -- then she sank her teeth into the base of my thumb and she drew blood. I began to shriek, from pain and from surprise; but she looked at me and I fell silent.

The little Princess fastened her mouth to my hand and drank. When she was finished, she left my chamber. Beneath my gaze the cut that she had made began to close, to scab, and to heal. The next day it was an old scar: I might have cut my hand with a pocket-knife in my childhood.

I had been frozen by her, owned and dominated. That scared me, more than the blood she had fed on. After that night I locked my chamber door at dusk, barring it with an oaken pole, and I had the smith forge iron bars, which he placed across my windows.

My husband, my love, my king, sent for me less and less, and when I came to him he was dizzy, listless,

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confused. I ran my fingers across his skin as he slept. It was covered in a multitude of ancient scars.

Soon he was a shadow of the man I had met and loved by the bridge. I was with him at the last: his hands were cold as stone, his eyes milky-blue, his hair and beard faded and lustreless and limp. He died, his skin nipped and pocked from head to toe with tiny, old scars.

So I was queen.

If it were today, I would have her heart cut out, true. But then I would have her head and arms and legs cut off. I would have them disembowel her. And then I would watch, in the town square, as the hangman heated the fire to white-heat with bellows, watch unblinking as he consigned each part of her to the fire. And I would not close my eyes until the princess was ash, and a gentle wind could scatter her like snow.

I did not do this thing, and we pay for our mistakes.

They took her in the day, while she slept, and was at her weakest. They took her to the heart of the forest, and there they opened her blouse, and they cut

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out her heart, and they left her dead, in a gully, for the forest to swallow.

They brought me her heart. I know it was hers -- no sow's heart or doe's would have continued to beat and pulse after it had been cut out, as that one did.

Outside, the snow fell, covering the footprints of my huntsmen, covering her tiny body in the forest where it lay.

There were people in the forest. They would come out, some of them, for the Spring Fair: a greedy, feral, dangerous people; some were stunted -- dwarfs and midgets and hunchbacks; others had the huge teeth and vacant gazes of idiots. They would creep out of the forest each year for the Spring Fair, held when the snows had melted.

Spring Fair followed Spring Fair: five of them, each sadder, poorer, shoddier than the one before. Fewer of the forest folk came out of the forest to buy. Those who did seemed subdued and listless.

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The Lord of the Fair, and his page, came to me when the fair was done. I had known him slightly, before I was queen.

"I do not come to you as my queen," he said. "I come to you because you are wise. You know secrets and you can seek out things hidden. My queen," he asked, "what is taking the forest folk? Next year there will be no Spring Fair. The travellers from other kingdoms have grown scarce and few, the folk of the forest are almost gone. Another year like the last, and we shall all starve."

I commanded my maidservant to bring me my looking-glass. It was a simple thing, a silver-backed glass disk, which I kept wrapped in a doe-skin, in a chest, in my chamber.

They brought it to me, then, and I gazed into it:

She was twelve and she was no longer a little child. Her skin was still pale, her eyes and hair coal-black, her lips as red as blood. She was standing in the forest, beside a tree.

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As I watched, in the eye of my mind, I saw her edge and step and flitter and pad from tree to tree, like an animal: a bat or a wolf. She was following someone.

He was a monk.She watched him from behind the trees. Eventually he paused for the night, and began to make a fire. He sat there in the firelight, and she came out from her hiding place. She crouched down on the other side of the fire, and stared at him. He grinned, as if it were a long time since he had seen another human, and beckoned her over to him. She sank her teeth deep into his breast. His eyes opened, then they closed again, and she drank.

I covered the mirror in doe-skin. I would personally take it upon myself to make the forest safe once more. I had to, although she terrified me. I was the queen.

I spent time with old books, for I could read a little. I prepared myself, and obtained those things I would need, and when the first snows began to fall, then I was ready. I carried a silver basin, and a basket in which I had placed a silver knife, a silver pin, some

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tongs, a grey robe and three green apples. I took the silver knife, and slashed my left arm -- once, twice, three times. The blood dripped into the basin, scarlet seeming black in the moonlight.

I added the powder from the vial that hung around my neck. It was a brown dust, made of dried herbs and the skin of a particular toad, and from certain other things. It thickened the blood, while preventing it from clotting. I took the three apples, one by one, and pricked their skins gently with my silver pin.

When dawn began to brighten the sky I covered myself with the grey cloak, and took the red apples. I buried the bowl in the earth. Then I cast a glamour on the apples that they were, beyond any doubt, the most wonderful apples in the world; and the crimson blush of their skins was the warm colour of fresh blood.

I pulled the hood of my cloak low over my face, and I took ribbons and pretty hair ornaments with me, placed them above the apples in the reed basket, and I walked alone into the forest, until I came to her

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dwelling: a high, sandstone cliff, laced with deep caves going back a way into the rock wall.

After some hours a clutch of dwarfs crawled out of the cave-front -- ugly, misshapen, hairy little men, the old inhabitants of this country.They vanished into the wood. I went to the cave entrance and hallooed into it, in a cracked old voice.

She was thirteen years of age, my stepdaughter, and nothing marred the perfect whiteness of her skin save for the livid scar on her left breast, where her heart had been cut from her long since.

She peered at me, hidden, as I was, in my cloak. She looked at me hungrily. "Ribbons, goodwife," I croaked. "Pretty ribbons for your hair..."

She smiled and beckoned to me. I did what I had planned to do: I dropped my basket, and screeched like the bloodless old pedlar woman I was pretending to be, and I ran. I made my way back to the palace.

I did not see it. Let us imagine though, the girl returning, frustrated and hungry, to her cave, and

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finding my fallen basket on the ground. What did she do?

I like to think she played first with the ribbons, twined them into her raven hair, looped them around her pale neck or her tiny waist. And then, curious, she moved the cloth to see what else was in the basket; and she saw the red, red apples.

They smelled like fresh apples, of course; and they also smelled of blood. And she was hungry. I imagine her picking up an apple, pressing it against her cheek, feeling the cold smoothness of it against her skin. And she opened her mouth and bit deep into it...

By the time I reached my chambers, the heart that hung from the roof-beam, with the apples and hams and the dried sausages, had ceased to beat. It hung there, quietly, without motion or life, and I felt safe once more.

The Spring Fair was slightly improved that year. The forest folk were few, but they were there, and there were travellers from the lands beyond the forest.

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I saw the little hairy men of the forest-cave buying and bargaining for pieces of glass. I thought, briefly, about having them killed, but I did not. As long as the heart hung, silent and immobile and cold, from the beam of my chamber, I was safe, and so were the folk of the forest, and, thus, eventually, the folk of the town.

My twenty-fifth year came, and my stepdaughter had eaten the poisoned fruit two winters' back, when the Prince came to my Palace. He rode with a small retinue: large enough to defend him, small enough that another monarch -- myself, for instance -- would not view him as a potential threat.

He left early the next morning, with all his men, and they rode off into the forest.

I imagine his pale lips pressed so tightly together. Then I imagine his little troupe riding through the forest, finally coming upon the glass-and-crystal cairn of my stepdaughter. So pale. So cold. Little more than a girl, and dead.

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In my fancy, I can almost feel the prayers he muttered beneath his breath in thanks for his good fortune. I imagine him negotiating with the little hairy men - offering them gold and spices for the lovely corpse under the crystal mound.

Did they take his gold willingly? Or did they look up to see his men on their horses, with their sharp swords and their spears, and realize they had no alternative?

I can only imagine... Hands, pulling off the lumps of glass and quartz from her cold body. Hands, gently caressing her cold cheek, moving her cold arm, rejoicing to find the corpse still fresh and pliable.

Did he shake the apple from her throat? Or did her eyes slowly open; did her mouth open, those red lips part, those sharp yellow teeth close on his swarthy neck, as the blood, which is the life, trickled down her throat, washing down and away the lump of apple, my own, my poison?

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I imagine; I do not know. This I do know: I was woken in the night by her heart pulsing and beating once more. Salt blood dripped onto my face from above.

There was a hammering on the door. I felt afraid, but I am a queen, and I would not show fear. I opened the door.

First his men walked in to my chamber, and stood around me, with their sharp swords, and their long spears. Then he came in; and he spat in my face. Finally, she walked into my chamber, as she had when I was first a queen, and she was a child of six. She had not changed. Not really.

Her prince put his arm around her nonetheless, and they stood, side by side. They told me they would marry, and the kingdoms would be joined. They have told the people bad things about me; a little truth to add savour to the dish, but mixed with many lies.

I was bound and kept in a tiny stone cell beneath the palace, and I remained there through the autumn. Today they fetched me out of the cell; they stripped the rags from me, and washed the filth from me.

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The snow was falling as they carried me through the midwinter crowds; and brought me to this kiln.

My stepdaughter stood there with her prince. She watched me but she said nothing.

As they thrust me inside, jeering and laughing as they did so, I saw one snowflake land upon her white cheek, and remain there without melting. She was not laughing, or jeering, or talking. She did not sneer at me or turn away. She looked at me, though; and for a moment I saw myself reflected in her eyes.

I will not scream. I will not give them that satisfaction. They will have my body, but my soul and my story are my own, and will die with me. I shall make no sound at all. I shall think instead of the snowflake on her cheek. I shall think of her hair as black as coal, her lips as red as blood, her skin, snow-white.

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